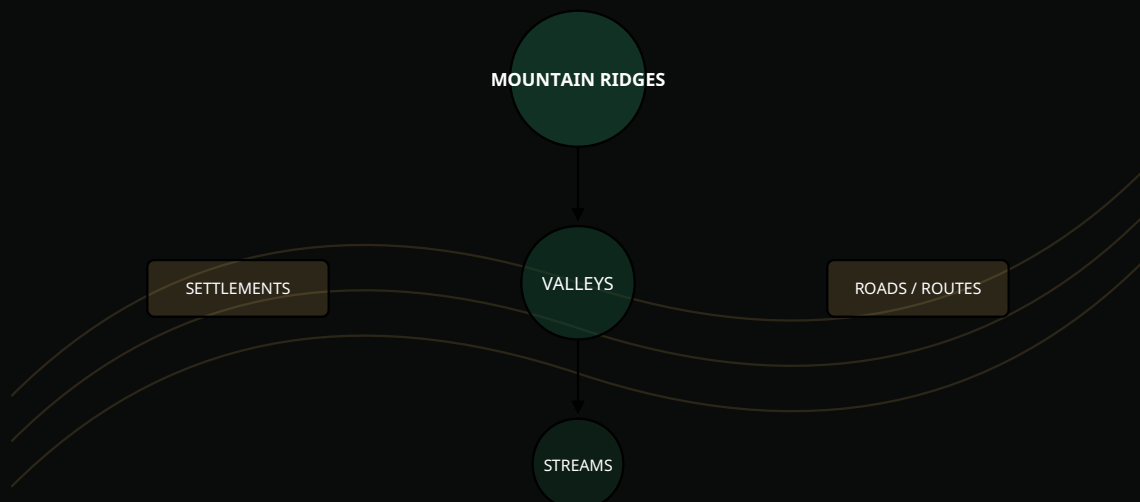


GEOGRAPHY OF ORAKZAI

“Mountains, valleys, water, climate and human settlement.”

Geography is not simply the shape of a place on a map. It is the relationship between land, water, climate, elevation, movement and human settlement. Orakzai is a mountainous region whose physical geography has influenced where people live, how they travel, how land is used, and how communities remain connected.

Geography influences human life without determining culture by itself. The physical environment provides the stage upon which the Orakzai people have built their history, adapting their livelihoods and social structures to the high ridges and fertile valleys of their homeland.¹²



“Stylized topographic landscape informed by the relationship between terrain and human infrastructure.”

GEOGRAPHIC PROFILE

REGION

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Pakistan

AREA

1,538 sq km (PBS, 2023)¹

TEHSILS

Central, Ismailzai, Lower, Upper Orakzai²

LANDSCAPE

Predominantly mountainous / hilly terrain

POPULATION

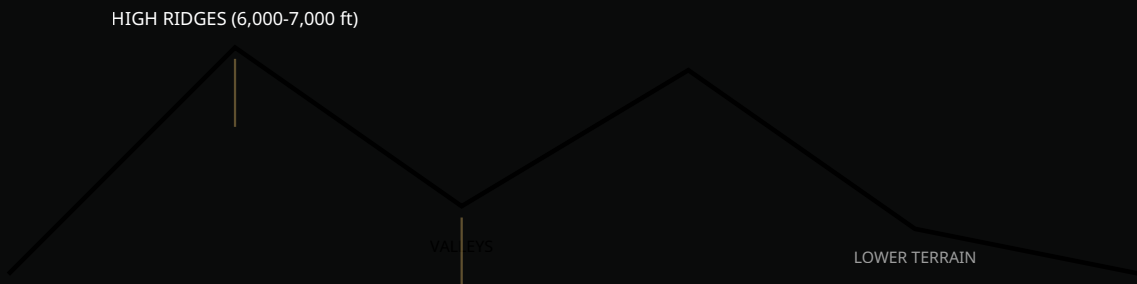
387,561 (Census 2023)¹

ELEVATION

6,000 to 7,000 ft (approx. 2,100m) peaks⁴

TOPOGRAPHY & ELEVATION

The topography of Orakzai is defined by a series of parallel mountain ranges and high ridges separated by fertile valleys. The elevation varies significantly, with peaks in the **Karagh Ghar** and **Samana Range** commanding the landscape. These high ridges influence travel, settlement, and agriculture, creating a naturally segmented but interconnected social world.³⁵



“Elevation profile illustrating the transition from high ridges to valley floors.”

MOUNTAINS & VALLEYS

The principal valleys—**Mastura**, **Khanki**, **Kharmana**, and **Bara**—serve as the primary areas for settlement and agriculture. These valleys are sheltered by the surrounding mountains, providing access to water and cultivable land. Historically, each valley developed its own community character while remaining part of the wider Orakzai tribal network.³⁴



“Conceptual model of the valley as a nexus for settlement.”

SLOPES & LAND USE

Slope gradient is a critical factor in Orakzai geography. Steep slopes limit flat land for construction and large-scale farming, leading to the development of terraced agriculture and settlements perched on valley sides. Valley floors, where land is more level and water more accessible, support higher settlement density.²⁵



“Cross-section model showing the geographic logic of land use.”

WATER GEOGRAPHY

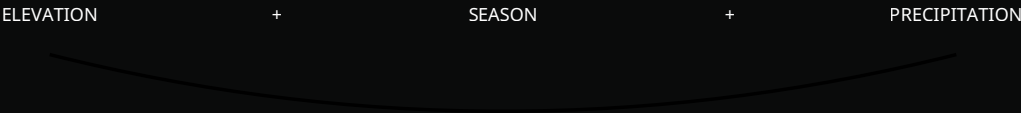
Water is the lifeblood of the region. The **Mastura River** and **Khanki Toi** are the primary perennial streams, originating in the western hills and flowing eastward. These rivers, along with seasonal watercourses and springs, provide the necessary hydration for drinking, livestock, and the 11.5% of land that is cultivated.²⁴



“The central role of water in supporting multiple dimensions of regional life.”

CLIMATE & SEASONS

The climate of Orakzai is influenced by its varied elevation. Winters can be severe, with significant snowfall in the higher Tirah regions, while summers remain relatively temperate in the upper valleys. Seasonal variations dictate the rhythm of agricultural life and movement.²⁵



“The interactive factors determining the regional climatic environment.”

WINTER

Significant snowfall in upper regions; limited movement; domestic focus.

SPRING

Thawing snow; replenishment of watercourses; beginning of cultivation.

SUMMER

Temperate in upper valleys; peak agricultural activity; seasonal rainfall.

AUTUMN

Harvest period; preparation for winter; changing vegetation colors.

ECOLOGICAL LAYERS

The region's vegetation reflects its mountainous character, with forest cover (approx. 3.5%) featuring species like **Pinus wallichiana**. Fertile valleys support fruit orchards, including walnut, apricot, and apple trees, which are integral to the local economy and diet.²⁵

WOODLAND / FOREST (PINUS WALLICHIANA)

SHRUBS / GRASSLAND

AGRICULTURAL VEGETATION / ORCHARDS

“The vertical distribution of vegetation types based on elevation and land use.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

To know the geography of Orakzai is to understand the rhythm of life itself. The steepness of the slopes taught us patience; the flow of the Mastura River taught us continuity. We are a people of the ridges and the valleys—our homes are built into the mountains, and our orchards

are a testament to our labor. The land is not just a place where we reside; it is a partner in our survival, a silent witness to the generations that have come before and those yet to follow.

“The mountain gives us our name, but the valley gives us our life.”

AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS
